



**Close encounter:** Neeraj with gold medallist Arshad Nadeem and bronze medallist Anderson Peters. GETTY IMAGES

he feels the dread of a sudden twinge inside his inner thigh. He constantly thinks about his injury.

When he throws, he says 70 per cent of his thoughts are about whether he will get injured. His runway approach was once characterised by speed; now, he's slowed down considerably.

He compensates for the lack of speed by using his arm even more. Compared to the massive muscles of the leg, Neeraj's far smaller right shoulder and arm now do all the work.

Compared to other athletes who are throwing 40 to 50 times each session, Neeraj says he is only able to have one throwing session every couple of weeks.

He almost did it. Even after Arshad threw a massive 92.97m, Neeraj didn't think he was done. Slow off the runway, using almost exclusively his arm to propel the javelin, he nearly reached 90m himself.

At the Olympic finals, though, his

groin wasn't cooperating. His fouls were a consequence of his overthinking about a potential injury — a vicious cycle.

He thinks about a possible injury during a run-up, which leads to a poor one and consequently an 'X' against his name when he can't avoid the foul line. It's a sequence that, he says, mentally breaks him.

You can tell Neeraj is hurting after the event. He has spoken before about the reason he got into javelin. He does it because he loves it — he loves to throw. But throwing is hard for him right now.

He is doing it with a handicap. He'd love to throw freely. The fact that he has been this consistent is entirely due to hard work and injury management. His coaches say he can add three to four metres if he finally gets his groin treated.

That's what Neeraj wants too.

"There is a big throw inside me, but I'm not able to do it. Medals are one thing. But I want to get the distance I had in 2018 when I first threw 88m at the Asian Games. I feel I have a lot of good throws in me. I will not be at peace until I get that," he says.

Neeraj has been considering

surgery to treat his groin for several years now. However, the procedure is complex, and recovery will take several months. While Neeraj might have the time, India does not.

"My doctor told me to do the surgery before the last World Championships, but I didn't have time to decide because it takes a lot of time to prepare for the Olympics," he says.

"*Khainch ke chal raha hoon*," Neeraj says. He's been dragging himself to this finish line.

Now that he has reached it and given his country another Olympic medal, Neeraj can do what he really needs to do — talk to his doctors and decide when to do the surgery.

But not on the day of the final.

That day, Neeraj had one solitary goal. While he fell just short of the step he had hoped to stand on the podium, he's done more than everyone before him.

He wants to make sure of that too. When he came into the mixed zone, that's what he wanted to know as well. "You guys are satisfied, right?" he asked.

Only when everyone said they were did he finally head back to the Olympic Village.